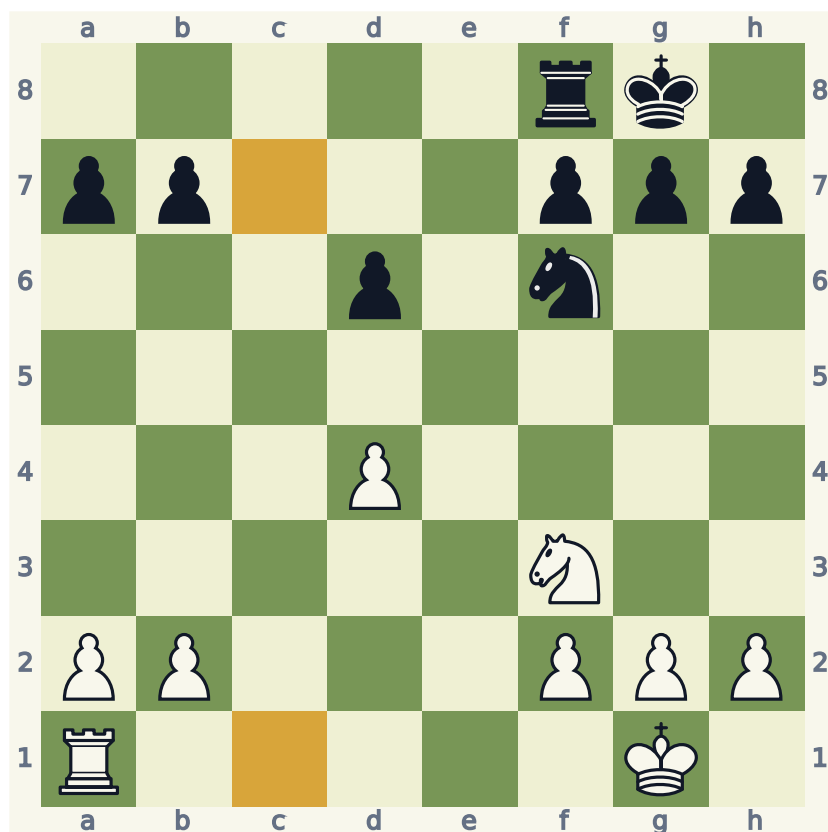


Open and semi-open files

A file matters when it leads somewhere.

An open file has no pawns of either side; a semi-open file has no friendly pawn but contains an enemy pawn. Rooks use these files to pressure targets and reach entry squares. Occupying a file is only a first step: ask where the rook can penetrate and whether the opponent can contest it.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- The c-file contains no pawns or pieces.
- c7 is an entry square that Black's current pieces do not control.
- The a1-rook can use the file in two moves.

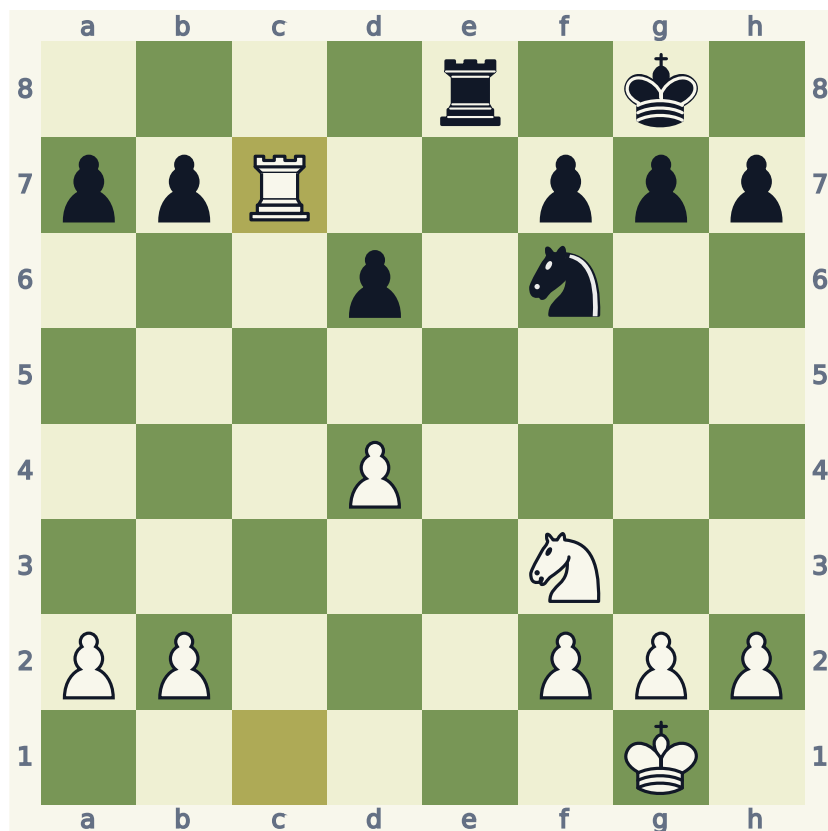
REMEMBER

- Name the entry square or pawn target.
- Check every square along the rook's route.
- Contest the file before the enemy enters.

Follow the logic

1. Rc1 Re8 2. Rc7

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Rc1

Occupy the file with a destination in mind. The rook is aiming for c7, where it can attack b7 and f7.

...Re8

Black chooses activity on a different file. This does not stop the c-file invasion; a stronger defense might contest it.

Rc7

The rook reaches the seventh rank and attacks b7 and f7. Its pressure stops at the first pawn in each direction; it does not attack through f7 to g7.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should look for ...Rc8 before White enters, or for a tactical response to the invasion. A file may be neutralized if every entry square is controlled even when no enemy rook occupies it.

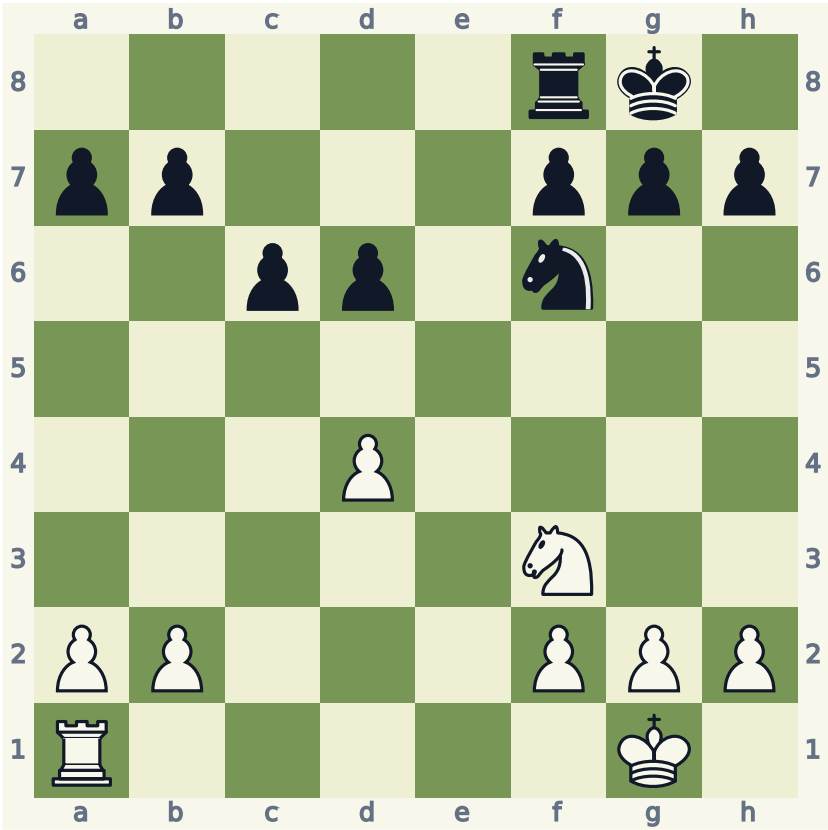
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not say a rook attacks a pawn just because it is nearby. Trace the exact rank or file and check intervening pieces. An open file without a usable entry square may be only a modest asset.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Is the c-file open or semi-open for White?
- 2. What is the first target of Rc1?
- 3. Why can the rook not simply play Rc7 next?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black could safely play ...c5, how would the target change?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pp3ppp/2pp1n2/8/3P4/5N2/PP3PPP/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. The c-file is semi-open because White has no c-pawn and Black has a pawn on c6. That pawn changes both the target and the rook's route.
2. Rc1 pressures c6 along the file. White may add an attacker, fix c6 so it cannot advance safely, or create another weakness while Black defends it.
3. The c6-pawn physically blocks the route from c1 to c7. White would have to remove or bypass it first. A file label must be connected to the actual squares a rook can reach.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Rc1 Re8

Changed feature: The pawn might stop being a fixed weakness and could challenge d4. White should calculate the advance before committing all pieces to attacking c6.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Find an open file in a game. List every possible entry square and the enemy piece that controls each one.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 12, 13, 18. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.